

The 82d Opener Will Be Last in Offermann Stadium

By MAURY MAY

THERE'LL probably be many a misty-eyed spectator when the Buffalo Bisons play their last opening-day baseball game in historic old Offermann Stadium Wednesday afternoon.

Among them will be Ollie Carnegie, the bow-legged former home run-hitting outfielder, one of the most popular players ever to wear a Bison uniform.

For Carnegie played in the

most openers (10) in Offermann Stadium, the third-oldest playing site in the country. Only Sportsman's Park (now Busch Stadium) St. Louis, and Crosley Field, Cincinnati, are older.

CARNEGIE JOINED the Bisons after the 1931 season started and played in every opener from 1932-1941. He returned in 1945 as coach. Carnegie had one of his best opening-day performances in 1933

when he had five hits, including a homer, in eight times at bat in a double-header loss to Jersey City. He holds the club home-run record of 45 and the International League homer record (258) and runs-batted-in record (1044).

AS THE BISON fans wend their way into the old ballpark's 82d consecutive opener their thoughts also will range back to olden days of Carnegie and Ollie Tucker and

Beauty McGowan of the '30's . . . to Del Bissonette, Andy Cohen and Billy Kelley of the 20's . . . to Hank Gowdy and Frank Gilhooley of the '10-era. Some of the real old-timers will recall seeing Jimmy Collins, Charley Stahl, Rube Kissinger, Billy Botenus and Jim Daly who played before the turn of the century.

MANY WILL remember Jack Hussey, who was traded to Rochester just a few hours

before the 1950 opener, then proceeded to drive in three runs, including the winner, for the Herd.

SOME WILL recall the 1926 opener and Joe Lucey who pitched a shutout in an abbreviated five-inning game, called after five innings because of snow. The only other Bison to pitch a shutout in an I. L. opener was Karl Drews in 1946. George (Chummy) Gray pitched a 1-0 no-hit opener for the Bisons in 1899, but it was a Western League game.

Buffalo's first opening-day game was played in 1878 in what was known as Riverside Park, located at Fargo and Rhode Island Sts., in the old International Association. A crowd of 2650 attended.

THE BISONs played in the National League from 1879-85, and in 1884 opened Olympic Park located in Richmond Ave. at Summer St. The first I. L. opener was in 1886 in Olympic Park, and the Bisons played some of their Sunday games in Floss or Franklin Park located at Genesee and Barthel. The first game played at the present site was in 1889.

Connie Mack, the famous owner-manager of the old Philadelphia A's, was among the old-time players to wear Bison livery. He was catcher-manager of the ill-fated Players' League team in the 1890 opener.

IN 1900 Buffalo almost became part of the American League, but Ban Johnson, the

league's founder, dropped Buffalo in favor of Boston. The Bisons were then known as the Pan-Ams in honor of the Pan-American Exposition.

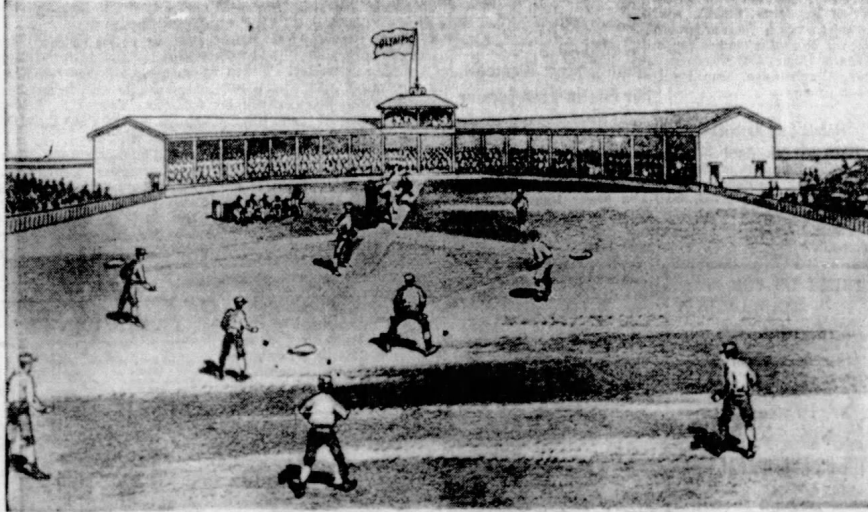
It was the old Federal League, which operated in Buffalo in 1914-15, which bragged of the record opening-day attendance, but historians believe the crowd of 18,281 was "padded." The league played its games at Jefferson and Northland, now known as Hamlin Park.

A RECORD throng is expected for the last home opener in the Michigan-Ferry park, but they'll have to pack 'em in to break the official I. L. home-opener record of 17,927 who saw Newark beat the Bisons and Lou Kretlow, 5-1, in 1946.

In more than three-quarters of a century, the Buffalos, the Bisons, the Pan-Ams and the Feds, as they have been called, have performed in six leagues—three major and three minor. They have played their games in six ball parks—five in the city and one in Cheektowaga.

Many hundreds of ballplayers, including seven immortalized in the Hall of Fame at Cooperstown, have worn Buffalo uniforms.

Some of the seasons proved profitable, others (and these were in the majority) left a trail of red ink on the ledgers. But, through profit and deficit, baseball wars, world wars, booms and depressions, Buffalo has never been without professional baseball for 81 consecutive years.



OLYMPIC PARK . . . WHERE THE BASEBALL BISONs PLAYED IN 1884
Bison's Defeated Detroit, 11-4, in Opener. (From a print in the Baseball Museum, Cooperstown.)